

GETTY IMAGES

That night on November 2, there were several heart-stopping moments when Indian cricket fans—a record 190 million of them watching the 2025 Women's Cricket World Cup final on television and streaming services, and another 40,000, dressed mostly in blue, present at the DY Patil Stadium in Navi Mumbai—sensed that victory for the home team was nigh. One was when an athletic Amanjot Kaur—already the star of a stunning direct runout—took a fumbling, tumbling sky-high catch that stopped South Africa captain Laura Wolvaardt in her tracks just as she seemed poised to take the game away from India. Another was when Deepti Sharma yorked Annerie Dercksen to take the third of her match-winning five wickets—all that after a steadying, run-a-ball 58 while batting. Then there was the stroke of pure genius by captain Harmanpreet Kaur, Harry Di to teammates, when she took the high-risk gambit of getting Shafali Verma, known more for wielding the willow, to bowl. Verma delivered handsomely by taking two priceless wickets. Finally, the captain herself took a magical leaping catch to close off the match.

'Harry's Heroines'—most born a generation after Kapil's Devils—have scripted not just India's first-ever women's World Cup victory but etched out a game-changing moment for gender empowerment in the country. "It's a win for the ages," declared cricket legend Sunil Gavaskar, who was part of that legendary team that won India's first men's World Cup in 1983. "It will rank as one of the greatest in the history of Indian cricket." Tennis star Sania Mirza, who had herself blazed a lonely trail, turned emotional, saying, "This win feels personal. The next time a young girl tells her parents, 'I want to be a Smriti Mandhana', they will not think it is a ridiculous dream." Ten-year-old Straina Soumya Biswal, a Smriti fan, perhaps encapsulated that exact sentiment as

Harmanpreet Kaur | 36 |

Innings: 8; Runs: 260; Average: 32.5

We know how it feels to lose, but we are really looking forward to seeing how it feels to win," said Harmanpreet Kaur after the semis. The lady from Moga, Punjab, had experienced the heartbreaks of the 2017 WC final, when India lost by nine runs to England and the T20 World Cup final in 2020 when India was outclassed by Australia. In her maiden ODI World Cup as captain, Kaur was on a mission to exorcise those demons as a leader respected by all team members, besides being the emotional core of the squad. Whether it was to go with her gut feeling and give the ball to Shafali Verma in the final or forging that incredible 167-run third-wicket partnership with Jemimah in the semis, 'Harry Di', as she's known amongst the girls, was the leader who delivered when it mattered most.